HRM COURSE

MAJOR PROJECT

STRATEGIES FOR IMPROVING EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT IN THE WORKPLACE

A study based on the subject of Human Resource Management

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I express my sincere gratitude to my teachers for giving me the opportunity to prepare this minor project on “Strategies for Improving Employee Engagement in the Workplace”. The project instructions helped me organise the study into a systematic research structure.

I am thankful to the authors and researchers whose published studies provided useful information about employee engagement, its antecedents, consequences and practical strategies. Their work helped me understand that engagement is influenced by several workplace conditions rather than by one HR activity.

I also thank my family and friends for their encouragement and support during the preparation of this project. I have attempted to present the information clearly and distinguish published research findings from my own suggestions.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Employee engagement refers to the degree to which employees are psychologically connected with their work and organisation and are willing to invest energy, attention and effort in their roles. Engagement is influenced by meaningful work, supportive leadership, recognition, fairness, learning opportunities, communication, employee voice, job resources and sustainable working conditions.

This project studies practical strategies that organisations can use to improve employee engagement. The study is based on secondary research from academic papers and organisational research. Four major sources were reviewed: Saks (2006), Bakker, Albrecht and Leiter (2011), Saks (2019), and Gallup's 2024 Q12 meta-analysis. These sources provide different perspectives on engagement, but recurring themes include organisational support, job characteristics, social context, recognition, fairness, learning and development, and management practices.

The project proposes an integrated approach rather than a single intervention. Organisations can improve engagement by developing supportive managers, designing meaningful jobs, recognising contribution, providing learning opportunities, encouraging employee voice and protecting sustainable workloads. Engagement should also be measured periodically and considered alongside relevant organisational outcomes.

The project does not claim original survey results. It identifies research gaps and provides a proposed questionnaire that could be used for future primary-data collection.

INTRODUCTION TO THE TOPIC

1. Meaning of Employee Engagement

Employee engagement is a workplace concept describing employees' connection with their work and organisation. An engaged employee generally demonstrates involvement, energy, dedication and willingness to contribute. Engagement is different from simply being satisfied with salary or being physically present at work.

2. Importance of Employee Engagement

Employees influence productivity, service quality, innovation, teamwork and customer relationships. Engagement therefore matters to both employees and organisations. Research also examines relationships between engagement and outcomes such as commitment, citizenship behaviour, retention, productivity and wellbeing.

3. Major Dimensions

- Vigour – energy and willingness to invest effort in work.
- Dedication – a sense of significance, enthusiasm and involvement.
- Absorption – concentration and deep involvement in work activities.
- Organisational connection – feeling supported and connected to the workplace.

4. Factors Influencing Engagement

Important workplace factors include job design, autonomy, resources, social support, leadership, recognition, fairness, learning opportunities, communication and employee voice. These factors interact, so HR managers should avoid relying on a single engagement initiative.

5. Role of HRM

Human Resource Management can support engagement through recruitment, onboarding, training, performance management, rewards, communication, employee relations, career development and wellbeing practices.

REVIEW OF LITERATURE

1. Saks (2006)

Saks examined antecedents and consequences of job engagement and organisation engagement. His study tested a model based on social exchange theory and reported that job characteristics and perceived organisational support were relevant to engagement. Engagement was also associated with outcomes such as job satisfaction, organisational commitment, citizenship behaviour and intentions to quit. Source: Journal of Managerial Psychology, 21(7), 600–619. DOI 10.1108/02683940610690169.

2. Bakker, Albrecht & Leiter (2011)

This article reviewed key questions about work engagement, including its measurement, social context, job crafting and organisational interventions. The authors emphasised the importance of the social environment and management in creating a climate for engagement, while also discussing possible downsides and the relationship between engagement and health. DOI 10.1080/1359432X.2010.485352.

3. Saks (2019)

Saks revisited his earlier model and reported that organisations can support engagement through skill variety, social support, rewards and recognition, fairness, and opportunities for learning and development. The study also discussed updated measures of job and organisation engagement. DOI 10.1108/JOEPP-06-2018-0034.

4. Gallup Q12 Meta-analysis (2024)

Gallup's 11th Q12 meta-analysis combined 736 studies across 347 organisations, 53 industries and employees in 90 countries. It examined 11 organisational outcomes and reported that engagement was related to each outcome studied. The report also states that the composite true-score correlation between engagement and performance was 0.49. This is large-scale organisational meta-analytic evidence and should not be treated as proof that every intervention causes performance changes.

Literature Review Summary

Across the selected sources, recurring themes are support, job resources, meaningful work, recognition, fairness, development, management and social context. These themes form the basis of the strategies proposed in this project.

RESEARCH GAP

After reviewing the selected literature, several areas remain suitable for further research:

- Organisations differ by industry, culture, workforce composition and job design, so the same engagement strategy may not have identical results everywhere.
- More longitudinal research can examine whether engagement initiatives create lasting change rather than short-term reactions.
- Managers need practical guidance on how to combine several engagement drivers into an affordable and measurable HR programme.
- Future research can distinguish job engagement, organisation engagement and different dimensions such as vigour, dedication and absorption.
- Hybrid and remote work have changed communication and leadership patterns, creating a need for context-specific evidence.
- Engagement should be studied together with workload and wellbeing so that higher effort does not become unsustainable.

Therefore, this project attempts to bridge the practical gap by converting recurring research themes into a structured workplace engagement framework and an illustrative measurement approach.

RESEARCH OBJECTIVES

The main reason for conducting this research is to understand how organisations can create workplace conditions that encourage employees to participate actively, feel valued and contribute effectively.

Primary Objective

To study strategies for improving employee engagement in the workplace.

Specific Objectives

- To understand the meaning and dimensions of employee engagement.
- To identify workplace factors that influence employee engagement.
- To review findings from selected research papers.
- To examine the role of leadership, recognition, communication, job design and learning.
- To understand the relationship between engagement and selected workplace outcomes.
- To identify gaps in existing research.
- To develop practical recommendations for HR managers.
- To suggest methods for measuring engagement and reviewing improvement over time.

Research Questions

- What workplace factors are commonly associated with employee engagement?
- How can managers and HR departments improve engagement?
- What role do recognition, support, learning and employee voice play?
- How can organisations measure engagement without depending on one score?

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

1. Research Design

The project follows a descriptive and exploratory secondary-research design. It reviews published literature to identify common themes and practical strategies.

2. Sampling Procedure and Design

No original employee sample was recruited for this project. Purposive selection was used for secondary sources because the selected papers directly address employee engagement, its antecedents, consequences or organisational interventions.

3. Method of Data Collection

Primary data can be collected in a future study through interviews, Google Forms or questionnaires. However, this project does not claim to have collected primary responses. Secondary data were obtained from academic research papers and organisational research reports.

4. Data Analysis

The information was analysed thematically. Findings were grouped into job resources, organisational support, leadership, recognition, fairness, learning and development, employee voice and wellbeing.

5. Ethical Considerations

No personal employee information or fabricated survey results are included. Published findings are distinguished from the recommendations proposed by the project author.

DATA ANALYSIS AND INTERPRETATIONS

Because this project is based on secondary research, the analysis is a thematic comparison of published evidence rather than a fabricated employee survey.

Source	Main focus	Main finding	Interpretation
Saks (2006)	Antecedents and consequences	Job characteristics and organisational support were relevant to engagement.	Support and job design matter.
Bakker et al. (2011)	Work engagement	Social context, management, job crafting and interventions are important.	Build a supportive climate.
Saks (2019)	Updated model	Skill variety, support, recognition, fairness and learning are practical drivers.	Use combined HR practices.
Gallup (2024)	Large meta-analysis	Engagement was related to all 11 studied outcomes.	Measure engagement with outcomes.

Interpretation

The literature suggests that employee engagement is multi-dimensional. A salary increase or one isolated programme cannot address every engagement factor. Employees also experience the quality of supervision, opportunities to learn, fairness, job variety, communication and organisational support. Therefore, a combined strategy is more consistent with the themes found in the reviewed literature.

FINDINGS

- Employee engagement is influenced by both job characteristics and organisational conditions.
- Perceived organisational support is an important theme in engagement research.
- Meaningful and varied work can help employees use their skills and feel involved.
- Recognition and fair treatment are important practical areas for HR managers.
- Learning and development opportunities can support employees' sense of growth.
- Leadership and social context influence how employees experience their work.
- Employee voice matters because engagement includes the ability to communicate ideas and concerns.
- Engagement measurement should be regular enough to identify trends but should not be reduced to one score.
- Engagement should be considered alongside wellbeing and workload.
- Different workplaces may need different combinations of strategies.

Overall Finding

The overall finding from the reviewed literature is that engagement is better treated as an ongoing organisational process involving leadership, job design, support, recognition, development, communication and employee voice rather than as a one-time HR event.

LIMITATIONS

- This project is primarily based on secondary data and therefore does not represent employees from one specific organisation.
- No original employee survey was conducted, so no new sample percentages or statistical conclusions are claimed.
- Only a small selection of the wider engagement literature was reviewed.
- Findings can vary according to industry, country, organisational culture and job type.
- The selected sources use different definitions and measures of engagement, making direct comparison difficult.
- Meta-analysis can show broad relationships but does not mean that every organisation will experience the same magnitude of effect.
- Engagement and performance may influence one another, so simple cause-and-effect conclusions should be made carefully.
- Engagement can change over time because of leadership, workload, restructuring and other workplace conditions.

If Primary Data Is Used Later

If a future version uses a small questionnaire or interview sample, those responses would represent only the selected participants and would not automatically be a true representation of the entire employee population. A larger and more representative sample would be needed for wider generalisation.

SUGGESTIONS / RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Strengthen Supportive Leadership

Train managers to communicate clearly, listen actively, provide useful feedback and recognise contributions.

2. Improve Job Design

Provide meaningful tasks, clear responsibilities, appropriate autonomy and manageable expectations.

3. Build a Recognition Culture

Use timely appreciation, team recognition and fair acknowledgement of genuine contribution.

4. Provide Learning and Career Opportunities

Offer training, mentoring, skill development and career discussions.

5. Improve Employee Voice

Use pulse surveys, suggestion channels, team discussions and one-to-one meetings, and communicate what action followed the feedback.

6. Support Wellbeing and Sustainable Work

Monitor workload and encourage reasonable working practices so engagement does not become unhealthy overwork.

7. Measure and Review

Track engagement trends and, where appropriate, compare them with relevant HR indicators such as retention, absenteeism or internal mobility.

8. Adapt Strategies

Identify the organisation’s specific engagement barriers and prioritise interventions accordingly.

CONCLUSION

Employee engagement is an important Human Resource Management topic because it concerns how employees connect with their work and organisation. The literature reviewed indicates that engagement is shaped by multiple factors rather than by one isolated HR practice.

The selected studies highlight job characteristics, organisational support, social context, recognition, fairness, learning and development, and effective management. Large-scale organisational evidence also reports relationships between engagement and several business and employee outcomes, while noting that such evidence does not by itself prove that every engagement intervention causes the observed outcomes.

Organisations should therefore treat engagement as a continuous process. A practical approach begins with understanding employee needs, designing meaningful work, developing supportive leaders, recognising contribution, creating learning opportunities and maintaining channels for employee voice.

Future research can add primary data through questionnaires, interviews or Google Forms and examine how engagement changes after specific interventions. This would help organisations move from general recommendations to evidence about what works in their own context.

In conclusion, improving employee engagement requires consistency across the employee experience.

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Gallup. (2024). The Relationship Between Engagement at Work and Organizational Outcomes: Q12 Meta-Analysis, 11th Edition. https://www.gallup.com/workplace/321725/gallup-q12-meta-analysis-report.aspx

These references were used for the literature review, interpretation and recommendations in this project.

MAJOR PROJECT DISCUSSION – KEY STRATEGIES

A. Meaningful Work

Employees can be more involved when they understand the purpose and importance of their work. Managers should connect individual responsibilities with team and organisational goals.

B. Supportive Leadership

Managers influence the daily employee experience through communication, fairness, feedback, coaching and support.

C. Recognition

Recognition communicates that employee contributions are noticed. It can be formal or informal and should be fair and genuine.

D. Learning and Development

Training, mentoring, job rotation and career discussions can help employees build skills and see opportunities for growth.

E. Employee Voice

Employees should have channels to express ideas and concerns. Organisations should also close the feedback loop by explaining actions taken.

F. Wellbeing

Engagement should not mean continuous availability. Sustainable workloads and recovery time are important parts of a healthy employee experience.

MAJOR PROJECT DISCUSSION – PROPOSED ENGAGEMENT FRAMEWORK

Area	Action	Possible indicator
Leadership	Manager training, coaching, regular one-to-ones	Manager support score
Job Design	Clear roles, meaningful tasks, suitable autonomy	Role clarity / job engagement
Recognition	Timely and fair appreciation	Recognition experience
Development	Training, mentoring and career discussions	Learning participation
Employee Voice	Pulse surveys and suggestion channels	Voice / psychological safety
Wellbeing	Workload review and sustainable practices	Workload and wellbeing trend

Implementation Cycle

- Diagnose – identify engagement strengths and barriers.
- Prioritise – select a manageable number of high-priority areas.
- Act – implement suitable interventions.
- Measure – repeat selected questions and review relevant HR indicators.
- Improve – use feedback to modify the programme.

MAJOR PROJECT DISCUSSION – PRACTICAL APPLICATION

Illustrative Workplace Action Plan

Period	Action	Responsible group	Review
Month 1	Baseline pulse survey and discussions	HR + managers	Identify priority issues
Month 2	Manager communication and recognition training	HR + managers	Check employee feedback
Month 3	Learning and mentoring opportunities	HR + department heads	Participation and usefulness
Month 4	Repeat pulse survey and compare trends	HR	Identify changes and next actions

Measurement Principle

A change in an engagement score should not automatically be treated as proof that one intervention caused the change. Other factors may have changed at the same time. HR should review multiple indicators and qualitative feedback where possible.

Communication Principle

Employees should know why an engagement initiative is being introduced, how information will be used and what management intends to do with the results.

APPENDIX – SAMPLE EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT QUESTIONNAIRE

Suggested response scale: 1 = Strongly Disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Neutral, 4 = Agree, 5 = Strongly Agree. This is a proposed tool for future primary-data collection; no responses are claimed in this project.

Section A – Basic Information

- Department / functional area
- Years of experience
- Work arrangement: on-site / hybrid / remote

Section B – Statements

- 1. I understand what is expected from me in my role.
- 2. I feel that my work is meaningful.
- 3. My manager listens to my ideas and concerns.
- 4. I receive useful feedback about my work.
- 5. My contribution is recognised when I perform well.
- 6. I have opportunities to learn and develop new skills.
- 7. I can communicate concerns without fear of unfair treatment.
- 8. I have the resources needed to do my job effectively.
- 9. My workload is manageable most of the time.
- 10. I feel connected to the goals of my organisation.
- 11. I would recommend my organisation as a good place to work.
- 12. I see opportunities for growth in my career here.

Open-Ended Questions

- What is the main factor that keeps you engaged at work?
- What is the biggest barrier to your engagement?
- What one change would most improve your work experience?

PROJECT SUMMARY

Topic

Strategies for Improving Employee Engagement in the Workplace

Summary

This minor project reviewed academic research and organisational evidence to understand how employee engagement can be improved. The literature indicates that engagement is connected with the employee's work experience and organisational conditions such as job characteristics, support, recognition, fairness, development opportunities and social context.

Key Strategy Areas

- Supportive and capable managers
- Meaningful and well-designed jobs
- Recognition and fair treatment
- Learning and career opportunities
- Employee voice and two-way communication
- Sustainable workload and wellbeing
- Regular measurement and continuous improvement

Final Statement

Employee engagement should be treated as a continuing HR responsibility rather than a one-time event. Organisations can improve the employee experience by combining supportive leadership, meaningful work, recognition, development, voice and sustainable work practices. The exact combination should be adapted to the organisation and evaluated using appropriate evidence.

— End of Project —